PRESS INFORMATION · AUGUST 2026

Armenia LLM Summer School 2026 & Hack Armenia

Two connected events held in Yerevan in August 2026: a five-day school teaching how modern AI language models are built, followed immediately by a 24-hour **hackathon** in which teams built working AI tools for Armenian public services — health, law, water, agriculture, emergency response.

Aug 3–7	Aug 8–9	76	16
Summer School	**Hack Armenia**	**participants**	**projects built**
five days of teaching	24-hour build sprint	from 110 applicants	in 24 hours

In one sentence

Armenia's flagship AI training programme brought together researchers from NVIDIA, Meta, Google and Amazon to teach 76 selected engineers and students — who then had 24 hours to build software that solves a real Armenian problem. Sixteen working prototypes were produced and judged by a ten-person expert jury.

ORGANISED BY

Armenia LLM Summer School · AI9 Startup Campus · YerevaNN

Venue: AI9 Startup Campus, 9 Isahakyan St, Yerevan · Contact: armeniallm@gmail.com · armllm.github.io/2026/hackathon

First, the basics

Written for readers who have not covered this before.

What is a hackathon?

A hackathon is a time-boxed building competition. Teams of three or four people are given a theme and a fixed, deliberately short window — here, 24 hours — to design, build and demonstrate a working piece of software. It is not a conference and not a lecture: nothing is presented that the team did not build in the room. At the end, each team demonstrates what actually runs, and a jury of experts scores the work. The word combines “hack”, meaning to build something quickly and inventively, with “marathon”.

Why do people do it?

The deadline is the point. A tight limit forces teams to cut an idea down to the part that matters and prove it works, rather than describing what they might build one day. For participants it is a way to test skills, meet collaborators and be seen by employers and investors. For a country, it turns theoretical training into concrete, publicly available prototypes in a weekend — and shows where local talent actually is.

And what is an “LLM”?

A large language model is the technology behind systems like ChatGPT: software trained on very large amounts of text that can read, summarise, answer questions and follow instructions in ordinary language. The Summer School teaches how such systems are built and, critically, how to measure when they are wrong. That matters because these models can produce confident, fluent answers that are false — which is why the hackathon's judging rubric awarded points specifically for testing failure cases and for refusing to answer when evidence was insufficient.

Why this one was unusual

Most hackathons are open-ended. Hack Armenia set a single theme — **Armenia's public interest** — and required every team to show evidence that their system worked, to name where it fails, and to publish their code openly. Several of the resulting projects address problems the state itself is trying to solve: customs paperwork, legal research, water data, emergency dispatch.

Part one · The Summer School

3–7 August 2026 · AI9 Startup Campus, Yerevan · third edition

The Armenia LLM Summer School is an annual programme teaching how large language models are built, trained and evaluated. It is taught by working researchers from leading AI labs, most of them of Armenian origin, who return to Yerevan to teach. Admission is competitive: applicants submit a CV and sit a technical assessment, and in the previous edition roughly three applied for every place.

The 2026 faculty and curriculum

André Martins	IST / Unbabel	Pre-training & intro to LLMs
Edgar Minasyan	NVIDIA	Post-training: SFT & reinforcement learning
Ivan Moshkov	NVIDIA	Test-time scaling
Aram Markosyan	NVIDIA	Agents & reasoning
Armen Aghajanyan	Perceptron AI	Advanced topics

Format
Five days of lectures and hands-on practical sessions, with an online track for the theory. Participants work on their own laptops with shared GPU access.

Who attends
Graduate and undergraduate students, researchers and working engineers. Fees are heavily subsidised, with student waivers of up to 90% so cost is not the barrier.

Track record
In the 2025 edition 248 people applied for 77 places. Participants in the 2024 exit survey rated lecture quality 4.5 out of 5.

Why it exists
Armenia has a strong engineering tradition and a fast-growing technology sector, but frontier AI training is concentrated in a handful of labs abroad. The school's purpose is to bring that teaching to Yerevan directly — so that people can learn how these systems work without leaving the country, and so that the expertise stays and compounds locally. The hackathon exists to make sure the week ends in something built rather than something merely understood.

Part two · Hack Armenia

8–9 August 2026 · AI9 Startup Campus · organised with AI9 and YerevaNN

Immediately after the school, participants and other selected applicants had 24 hours to build an AI system serving Armenia's public interest. Teams chose their own problem within that theme. Everything had to be built during the event, published as open source, and — unusually for a hackathon — accompanied by evidence that it actually worked.

110
applied

76
took part
63 accepted places

20
teams formed
3–4 people each

16
projects submitted

How the 24 hours ran

Kick-off Saturday 10:00 with the theme and rules. Teams formed and scoped their problem, then built through the night with **12 senior AI mentors** on site. Code freeze Sunday midday, then Demo Day at 13:00: five minutes per team, split between a talk and a live demonstration.

How it was judged

A **ten-person jury** scored every team on five criteria — the quality of the idea and its fit to a real Armenian need; whether the prototype actually worked; the strength of the evaluation evidence; awareness of failure modes and safety; and whether it could survive outside the demo.

Who was in the room

Participants came from Yerevan, Gyumri, Dilijan, Ijevan, Hrazdan and abroad, and included ML researchers, security engineers, data scientists, product managers, university students and first-time hackathon entrants. Mentors and jurors came from NVIDIA, OpenAI, YerevaNN, AI9, Nebius, ServiceNow Research, PMI Science Armenia, Ucom, Wirestock and Armenian startups, alongside the First Deputy Minister of High-Tech Industry.

The rule that shaped the results

Teams were told an LLM had to *earn its place*: if a simpler tool would do the job, use the simpler tool. Points were awarded for measuring accuracy against a baseline, for naming who could be harmed when the system fails, and for making the model abstain rather than guess. That is why several of the winning projects refuse to answer when the evidence is thin.

Who made it possible

Prizes, compute, funding and venue.

OpenAI	Sponsored the hackathon prizes with API credits: **$12,000** for first place, **$7,500** for second and **$5,000** for third — credit toward the computing power needed to keep developing the winning projects.
Eleveight AI	Presented a separate **special prize** of $5,000-equivalent in GPUs — the specialised processors used to run AI models — so the winning team leaves with real computing hardware.
Ministry of High-Tech Industry of the RA	Supported Hack Armenia. First Deputy Minister **Gevorg Mantashyan** served on the jury, and the Ministry covered the event through its own channels.
ISAA	Supported the event alongside the Ministry.
Nebius & Yerevan State University	Provided the computing power for the Summer School. Nebius's Head of Solutions Architecture, Levon Sarkisian, also sat on the hackathon jury.
AI9 Startup Campus	Co-organiser and host venue for both events, in central Yerevan.
YerevaNN	Co-organiser. An Armenian non-profit machine-learning research lab; several of its researchers mentored teams.

Also supporting the Summer School

ARCS.ai and PMI Science R&D Center Armenia. Faculty travelled from NVIDIA, Perceptron AI and IST/Unbabel; past editions have drawn teaching staff from Meta, Google, Amazon and ServiceNow Research.

COMPUTE AND PARTNERS

The results

Judged by a ten-person jury on Demo Day, Sunday 9 August.

1ST PRIZE **OpenWater Armenia**

An interactive water-intelligence platform. Users pick any region of Armenia and ask questions in plain language; the system combines an LLM interface with deterministic geospatial and time-series analysis, answering from published water, climate, infrastructure and permit data while showing its sources and limitations.

2ND PRIZE **COPA**

A civic decision-intelligence system that turns Armenian-language citizen comments into structured, actionable information for public institutions — identifying individual issues, routing them to the right agency, flagging cases that need a human, and drafting replies without inventing administrative facts.

3RD PRIZE **Armenian Socratic Tutor** Team Random

An Armenian-language tutor that helps fifth-graders work through mathematics problems *without* revealing the answers. Grounded in Armenia's official textbook and teacher guide, it uses guiding questions and graded hints, with safeguards against answer leakage.

SPECIAL PRIZE **DeepClare** team HI

Turns commercial invoices, consignment notes and supplier catalogues into draft customs declarations for Armenia and the Eurasian Economic Union — preparing Armenian product descriptions, assigning commodity codes and generating declaration files with a human-review report, abstaining whenever the evidence is insufficient.

What the winners have in common

All four are grounded in real Armenian data — published water and climate records, ARLIS legislation, the national school textbook, customs classification rules — rather than generic demonstrations. All four cite their sources, and three of them explicitly refuse to answer when the evidence is insufficient, which was rewarded by the judging rubric. Every project is open source.

Every team's score is published on the official leaderboard — link supplied with this pack on request.

Other projects built that weekend

A selection of the sixteen submissions. All code is public.

ARM Triage AI	**Anthro AI Labs**	A guarded Armenian-language symptom navigator that points people to emergency, urgent or home care without issuing diagnoses, with deterministic emergency safeguards for elderly and rural users.
ResQ AI		A decision-support copilot for emergency dispatchers: it reads incoming call information, recommends a priority, asks clarifying questions when critical details are missing — and leaves the final decision to the dispatcher.
OpenLaw AM	**the Codefathers**	An open, auditable Armenian legal assistant grounded in legislation published through ARLIS. It cites its sources, refuses to answer when evidence is thin, and ships a public benchmark.
Heratsi	**Neighbourhood**	Reads a PDF or photographed laboratory report and organises it into something a patient can actually understand, in Armenian, Russian or English.
AgroShield	**The Overfitters**	Lets farmers report crop and vineyard problems by photo and description; reports are grouped into emerging patterns for expert review, with public maps showing only aggregated locations.
VulnFusion	**Cyber Hayq**	Merges findings from several cybersecurity scanners into one prioritised, explainable vulnerability report, keeping deterministic risk scores rather than letting the model invent them.
NewGround / ILARM	**Lytease**	A bilingual platform for the human side of resettlement programmes, turning free-text concerns from displaced households into structured cases that caseworkers can triage and track.
Secure Doc	**SecureDoc**	Converts free-text patient notes into a structured profile and checks medication safety against openFDA, PubMed and ClinicalTrials.gov, producing a cited brief for professional review.

Also submitted

ChronoLex, an Armenian legal-research assistant that finds which version of a law applied on a given date; Armenian.cc, which turns Armenian social-media video into learning material for Russian speakers; CarMed, a vehicle-diagnosis assistant built for how Armenians actually describe car faults, including Armenian written in Latin letters mixed with Russian terms; and a second Armenian Socratic maths tutor for Grade 7.

A note for reporting

These are 24-hour prototypes, not deployed government systems. They are best described as working demonstrations that show what is possible — several teams have said they intend to continue. The code for each is publicly available on GitHub, so any claim in this document can be checked.

Coverage, links and contacts

Already published

Public Radio of Armenia	en.armradio.am
First Channel News / 1Lurer	1lurer.am
NEWS.am Tech	tech.news.am
Ministry of High-Tech Industry of the RA	hightech.gov.am
How2B	how2b.am
EJC	ejc.am

Material available on request

Photographs from both events · team presentations and recorded demos · the full judging rubric · the official leaderboard with every team's score · introductions to winning teams, mentors, jurors and organisers for interview.

Press contact
Armenia LLM Summer School
armeniallm@gmail.com

Online
armllm.github.io
armllm.github.io/2026/hackathon

Suggested framing

The story is not that a hackathon happened. It is that 76 people, most of them Armenian engineers and students, spent 24 hours building AI tools for problems the country actually has — water data, customs paperwork, legal research, emergency dispatch, school mathematics — and that the work is public, checkable and, in several cases, continuing. The Ministry of High-Tech Industry backed it; OpenAI and Eleveight AI funded the prizes; the teaching that made it possible was delivered in Yerevan the week before by researchers who came home to teach.

Armenia LLM Summer School · AI9 Startup Campus · YerevaNN — Yerevan, August 2026